

Turning Data into Decisions: Sri Lanka and Australia Strengthens Data Driven Collaboration in Tourism

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Australia's Market Development Facility (MDF), in collaboration with the Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority (SLTDA), launched an initiative to support data-driven tourism planning in Sri Lanka. The programme titled "From Data to Decisions in Strengthening Tourism through Evidence and Collaboration" was held on November 27 at Amari Hotel Colombo with Deputy Minister Tourism Prof. Ruwan Ranasinghe representing Sri Lanka government and Australian High Commissioner to Sri Lanka Matthew Duckworth representing the Australian government. Key government representatives, together with industry leaders also attended the forum. They all explored how evidence-based research can build a more resilient tourism sector, taking successful examples of tourism developed countries.

Tourism Deputy Minister said Australia was the first country to take an initiative for data driven tourism development. "Sri Lanka's tourism sector has shown remarkable resilience in the face of recent challenges, its continued success depends on accurate, timely data to inform better decision making on policy, marketing and investments. Recognizing this, the Government of Sri Lanka has prioritized data driven planning, ensuring that future strategies for tourism are grounded in evidence and insight".

Australia and Sri Lanka have been collaborating since 2019 on strengthening Sri Lanka's tourism research capabilities. As part of this collaboration, Australia's MDF partnered with SLTDA to conduct a 12-month national airport exit survey between July 2024 and June 2025, covering over 11,000 inbound and 5,000 outbound travelers at the Bandaranaike International Airport. The survey provides comprehensive data on visitor trends, spending patterns and travel behavior.

The event also marked the official presentation of key findings from a 12-month National Airport Exit Survey. At this launch event, MDF and SLTDA revealed key insights from the survey: Younger tourists (20-35 years old) made up 46 per cent of travellers surveyed, with 46 per cent booking through online travel agents and 62 per cent opting to travel independently. Beaches topped the list of favourite experiences, while Galle,



Ella and Sigiriya emerged as the most visited destinations. Women travelers accounted for 58 per cent of all surveyed arrivals, and over 18 per cent of tourists were repeat visitors. Notably, 45 per cent of those surveyed said they planned to return. A comprehensive report with deeper insights and policy recommendations will be released soon according to MDF. Keynote speaker, Prof. Ranasinghe further said "Our vision is to make data a vital pillar of Sri Lanka's tourism transformation. Evidence allows us to plan strategically, invest wisely, and respond to global trends with confidence. With the support of partners like MDF, Sri Lanka aims to build a tourism industry that is competitive, and sustainable which is powered by data, collaboration, and innovation. Government, industry and development partners discussed the role played by reliable data in shaping tourism investments and